WhatsApp:

A Parent's Plain-English Guide

WhatsApp is the world's most used messaging app. It is simple, end-to-end encrypted and has almost no built-in protections for young people. Most parents use it for family chats and don't realise their child can be contacted by anyone with their number. This guide explains how it works, what the risks are, and what you can do.

2B+ Monthly active users globally

13+ Minimum age (widely bypassed)

FREE Simple, reliable, global

WHAT'S INSIDE

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06 Starting the conversation — How to talk to your child about WhatsApp

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01 WHAT IS WHATSAPP?

WhatsApp is a messaging app owned by Meta. It uses your phone number to connect with others. It is used for text, voice and video calls, group chats, photo and video sharing, and status updates.

Chats
One-to-one conversations. Messages, photos, videos, voice notes and documents.

Groups
Group chats with up to 1,024 members. Anyone in the group can see your phone number and profile.

Voice & Video Calls
High quality calls over the internet. One-to-one or in groups. No recording by default.

Status
24-hour updates visible to your contacts. Similar to Stories on other platforms.

Disappearing Messages
Messages that delete automatically after 24 hours, 7 days or 90 days.

End-to-End Encryption
Messages and calls are encrypted. WhatsApp cannot read the content.

WhatsApp's encryption is strong. That means no one can read messages in transit — not even WhatsApp. It also means there is no safety net if something goes wrong.



13+
Minimum age in the UK

Any child can enter a false date of birth. WhatsApp has no age verification. Most children who use WhatsApp are under 13.

Parental controls are limited because WhatsApp does not offer a parental account system.

WHAT PARENTS NEED TO UNDERSTAND FIRST

1. **It uses phone numbers** — Anyone with your child's number can message them unless their privacy settings are changed.
2. **Groups are powerful** — Your child can be added to groups by anyone — even people they don't know.
3. **Very little visibility** — You cannot see your child's chats or calls. Conversation is the most important tool.

BY THE NUMBERS

- **2 billion+ monthly active users globally** — WhatsApp is the most widely used messaging app in the world.
- **End-to-end encrypted by default** — Strong privacy and security, but no safety oversight.
- **No built-in protections for teens** — No age verification, no parental tools, no content controls.

02 HOW WHATSAPP WORKS IN PRACTICE

ONE-TO-ONE CHATS

- Anyorly private between two people.
- Includes text, photos, videos, voice notes and documents.
- Calls and messages are encrypted.
- No record is kept by WhatsApp.

GROUP CHATS

- Anyone with your number can add your child to a group.
- All members can see your child's phone number and profile photo.
- Groups can be large and fast-moving.
- Admins control who can join and post.

CALLS

- Voice and video calls are encrypted.
- Your child can call anyone who has their number.
- Group calls are possible too.
- No call recording by default.

DISAPPEARING IS NOT DISAPPEARANCE

Disappearing messages delete from both devices after the time you choose. They can still be:

- Screenshotted
- Forwarded before they disappear
- Seen on other devices
- Reported to WhatsApp

It adds privacy, not safety.

03 PRIVACY AND SECURITY: WHAT IT DOES (AND DOESN'T) DO

WHAT IT DOES

- End-to-end encryption for messages and calls.
- Two-step verification to protect account access.
- Block and report tools for unwanted contact.
- Control over who can see your profile info.
- Disappearing messages for extra privacy.

WHAT IT DOESN'T DO

- No age verification or teen accounts.
- No parental account or supervision tools.
- No content filtering or monitoring.
- No visibility for parents.

04 SETTINGS WORTH CHANGING

Last Seen & Online — Control who can see when your child was last online.	Settings > Privacy > Last Seen & Online
Profile Photo — Choose who can see their profile picture.	Settings > Privacy > Profile Photo
About — Choose who can see their About information.	Settings > Privacy > About
Groups — Decide who can add them to group chats.	Settings > Privacy > Groups
Blocked Contacts — Block unwanted contacts and numbers.	Settings > Privacy > Blocked Contacts
Disappearing Messages — Set chats to disappear automatically (24 hours, 7 days or 90 days).	Open chat > Contact name > Disappearing Messages

05 THE RISKS WORTH KNOWING

Stranger contact
Anyone with your child's number can message them. Many adults pretend to be teens.

Group risks
Your child can be added to groups with strangers. Content and conversations vary widely.

Scams and phishing
Links and messages can lead to scams, fake giveaways and phishing attacks.

Oversharing
Location, school, routines and personal information can be shared easily.

Forwarding and screenshots
Content can be forwarded, saved or screenshotted before it disappears.

Off-platform grooming
WhatsApp is frequently used to move conversations away from safer platforms.

06 THE 10-MINUTE CONVERSATION



- Ask open questions about who they chat to.
- Explain why some people pretend to be someone they are not.
- Talk about what not to share (location, school, routines, photos).
- Agree on what to do if something feels wrong.
- Remind them they can always come to you.

The "10-minute chat"
Sit down with your child and ask them to show you how they use WhatsApp, then listen without judging. It builds trust and opens the door.

Childline support: If you or a child you know needs support, Childline is available 24/7 at 0800 1111 or childline.org.uk.

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